Ioana Frîncu

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Summary

R&D product manager applying to PhD programs for Fall 2027. At imec I get researchers and engineers to agree on what a study measures, keep it honest while it runs, and write, edit and decide what we publish. Research interests: validity of agentic benchmarks (specification gaming, reliability), evaluation awareness in LLMs, measuring real AI workloads on next-generation hardware, technical governance, HCI.

Experience

imec · aistack — Ghent, Belgium
AI R&D Product Manager — *May 2026 – Present*

- Held back our SWE-bench Pro harness study after I ran a trajectory audit that showed agents reaching the reference fix in up to 90% of cases, depending on the model. Re-scoped it around the leak and split out evaluation awareness as its own question. Resolve rate on the clean re-run: 40–52%, down from 75–90% (write-up: Agents peeking)
- Scope the team's benchmark studies (16 researchers and engineers): pick the models, agent harnesses, hardware and concurrency for each run, and decide what is solid enough to publish. 6 studies published since May '26 (blog)
- Check every study against the construct-validity checklist from Bean et al. (2025) before it goes out. Chose task time and cost per solved task as headline metrics instead of tokens/s

OpenChip — Ghent, Belgium
AI Platform Product Owner — *Nov. 2025 – Apr. 2026*

- Made the call on the tenant identity model for a multi-tenant LLM inference platform (KServe, vLLM), working with 6 senior engineers

Microsoft · AI for Good Lab — Brussels / Remote
Product Management Intern — *Mar. 2025 – Nov. 2025*

- Ran the LINGUA grant program (open datasets for underrepresented European languages)

Twipe Digital Publishing — Leuven, Belgium
Product Owner — *Oct. 2023 – Mar. 2025*

- Ran every mobile and web release; replaced manual QA with automated E2E tests

Research & AI Safety

SPAR Fellow – Evaluation Awareness Convergence — Remote
Mentors: Netzer Epstein, Neta Ravid — *Sep. 2026 – Dec. 2026*

- Co-equal contributor; run the CoT and verbalized awareness benchmark conditions. Target: a paper by the end of the program

Peeking behavior of coding agents on SWE-bench Pro
Independent study — *Oct. 2026*

- Compared six models on a SWE-bench Pro subset under three conditions (default, git history scrubbed, prohibition prompt). Categorized verbal awareness and documented memory recall behavior. (Personal blogpost)

Iris.AI × Aalto University — Remote
Research Intern – NLP / LLM Evaluation — *Feb. 2023 – Sep. 2023*

- Designed and ran a human-subject study on soft vs hard prompt-tuning for LLM-generated abstracts: users wanted factual Q&A, and the generated abstracts were too broad for them. MSc thesis

AI Safety training — *May 2026 – Present*

- ML4Good technical bootcamp (Sep.–Oct. 2026), BlueDot Technical AI Safety (May 2026)

Skills

Evaluations: agentic benchmarks (SWE-bench Pro), agent trajectory analysis, human-subject studies, statistics (R)
Compute & infra: H200/B200 GPU benchmarking, LLM inference & serving (vLLM, KServe), Kubernetes, Docker
Code: Python, SQL, TypeScript
Languages: English (C2), Romanian (C2), Dutch (B2), French (A2)

Education

MSc Human–Computer Interaction & Design · EIT Digital double degree (Twente + Aalto) — *2021 – 2023*
BSc Communication Science + Philosophy Honors · University of Twente — *2017 – 2021*